

Wash, cut, style

Week 4, Lecture 2, Looksmaxxing

Evidence-Based Looksmaxxing · Autumn 2026

What we will cover

- Hair typing: the Andre Walker system and why it exists
- Shampoo and conditioner: what the ingredients do
- Wash frequency: why it varies dramatically by hair type
- Face-shape-matched cuts: the six shapes and the goal for each
- Talking to your barber: vocabulary, reference photos, and constraints

Hair typing

The Andre Walker system

- Developed by Andre Walker, longtime personal hairstylist to Oprah Winfrey, in the 1990s
- Four categories: 1 (straight), 2 (wavy), 3 (curly), 4 (coily/kinky)
- Three subcategories per number (A, B, C): fine-to-coarse within each texture
- Walker (2021): "The system was designed to help people figure out what products and techniques actually work for their hair type"
- It is a practical tool for matching care to texture, not a definitive biological classification

What each type needs differently

Type 1 (straight)	Prone to oiliness; less moisture needed; frequent washing OK
Type 2 (wavy)	Moderate moisture; avoid heavy products; every 2–3 days
Type 3 (curly)	High moisture needed; sulfate-free shampoo; 1–2x per week
Type 4 (coily)	Very high moisture; minimal washing; co-washing common

The letters (A, B, C) refine within each number: 4A is tight coils; 4C is dense zig-zag with less defined curl pattern.

Porosity (how readily hair absorbs moisture) adds a second axis: low-porosity hair repels products; high-porosity absorbs quickly but loses moisture fast.

Shampoo and conditioner

What shampoo does

- Shampoo contains surfactants: molecules with a water-loving head and an oil-loving tail
- Sulfates (SLS, SLES) are the most effective cleansers but strip natural oils aggressively
- Sulfate-free shampoos use milder surfactants: better for curly and coily hair, dyed hair, and scalp sensitivity
- Clarifying shampoos are high-surfactant; use once a month to remove product buildup, not as a daily routine

What conditioner does

- Conditioner deposits moisturizing agents (cetyl alcohol, behentrimonium chloride) and protein (hydrolyzed keratin) onto the hair shaft
- It temporarily fills gaps in the cuticle, reducing porosity and tangles
- Leave-in conditioner extends this effect for curly and coily types
- Deep conditioning (10-30 minutes) is used for high-porosity or chemically treated hair

Wash frequency by hair type

- **Straight (Type 1):** once a day to every other day. Sebum travels unimpeded down the shaft. Daily washing is fine and often necessary.
- **Wavy (Type 2):** every 2-3 days. More texture traps sebum; less frequent washing preserves wave definition.
- **Curly (Type 3):** 1-2 times per week. Curls need moisture; over-washing causes frizz and breakage.
- **Coily (Type 4):** once a week or less; co-washing (conditioner only) between washes is common. Sebum rarely reaches the ends of coily hair.

Over-washing strips the scalp of natural oils, which triggers increased sebum production. The goal is clean-not-stripped.

Face-shape-matched cuts

The goal is always the same

The objective of a face-shape-matched cut is to create the visual impression of an oval face: balanced length and width, no extreme narrowing or widening.

Matty Conrad (GQ, 2023): "The goal of a face-shape-matched haircut is to create the illusion of an oval face: add width where you are narrow, add length where you are round."

The cut does not change your face. It redirects attention and creates visual counterbalance.

The six shapes and the cut logic

Oval and round

Square and oblong

- Oval: almost any cut works. Use it as a reference.
- Round: add height on top, keep sides shorter. Avoid width above the ears.
- Square: soften the jaw with texture and length. Avoid very short sides that expose the angular jaw.
- Oblong: add width at the sides. Avoid very long, high cuts that add more vertical length.

Heart and diamond

Heart

Diamond

- Wide forehead, narrow chin.
 - Keep volume at or below the cheekbones.
 - Avoid height on top; it exaggerates the width difference.
 - A fringe or textured front can reduce apparent forehead width.
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- Narrow forehead, wide cheekbones, narrow jaw.
 - Add width at the forehead with a side part or fuller top.
 - Keep sides tight at the cheekbone level.

Accounting for hairline recession

- If temples are receding (early Norwood II-III), high skin fades that expose the temporal area make the recession more visible
- A lower taper or textured fade can frame the recession rather than expose it
- Longer texture on top with volume can balance a receding hairline at the temples
- Conrad (GQ, 2023) covers this directly: the cut should account for where your hairline actually is, not where it was at 18

Talking to your barber

Why communication is the hardest part

Most unsatisfying haircuts are a communication problem, not a skill problem.

Barbers are working in three dimensions on live hair with a growth pattern they have never seen before. They need information.

A barber brief has four elements:

1. The face-shape goal (add length, add width, reduce bulk)
2. The lengths: top and sides in concrete terms (inches or guard number)
3. The reference photo with a verbal note on what specifically you want to replicate
4. The constraints: cowlicks, recession, lifestyle, how much styling time you have

Vocabulary that travels

- **Fade:** a seamless gradient from very short at the skin to longer above. Low fade (above the ear), mid fade (at the temple), high fade (at the top of the sides).
- **Taper:** a gradual shortening toward the neckline and sides without going to skin.
- **Scissor over comb:** used for longer, textured cuts; more control than clippers.
- **Disconnected:** a clear line between a very short side and a longer top, with no gradual blend.
- **Texture:** removing bulk from the ends while keeping length; adds movement and reduces heaviness for thick hair.

Using reference photos well

- Bring two photos: a primary and an alternative
- Choose photos of men with a similar face shape and hair type to yours
- Point to the specific element you want: "I like the length here, not the fade level"
- Tell the barber what you know about your growth pattern: "My hair has a strong cowlick at the crown"
- If your primary photo has a styling requirement you cannot meet daily, say so: "I like this look but I want something that air-dries close to this without product"

"The system was designed to help people figure out what products and techniques actually work for their hair type: straight hair needs different care than coily hair, and the letters give you even more precision within each category."

<footer>Andre Walker, Andre Talks hair and the infamous hair typing system, 2021</footer>

Take-aways

1. The Andre Walker 1-4 A/B/C system is a care-matching tool: your type tells you how often to wash, how much moisture you need, and what products will not weigh your hair down.
2. Wash frequency should match your hair type: daily is fine for straight hair and potentially damaging for coily hair.
3. Every face-shape cut strategy aims at the same target: the oval face. Add what is missing, reduce what is excess.
4. Hairline recession changes which cuts work: account for your actual hairline, not an idealized one.
5. A barber brief with a reference photo, explicit lengths, a face-shape goal, and known constraints gives a skilled barber everything they need.

What is next

- **Section (this week):** reference photo selection, face-shape audit, and barber brief worksheet
- **Week 4 reading:** Hair, hair loss, and a haircut that fits your face
- **HW 2 out:** two-week skincare and grooming log
- **Week 5:** body composition: strength training, nutrition, and recomposition